‘My Body Feels Like it’s Coming Off’: Small Language Models, Bodies, and *Love is Blind*

Anonymized

In a reality TV dating show called *Love is Blind* (2020-present), a heterosexual, cisgender couple, Paul and Micah, take a romantic vacation to Mexico. They are about to jump into the crystal blue waters of a secluded cenote, when Paul sees something.

> Paul: What is that? Is that a shark?
> Micah: What do you mean shark?
> Paul: Oh, they're catfish. They look like baby, like, tiny nurse sharks.
> Micah: Okay, this is kind of scaring me. It's literally my worst nightmare if one of those touches me.
> Paul: These little catfish?
> Micah: Yeah.
> Paul: You're not their mommy. (*Love is Blind*, Season 4, Episode 5, “Paradise Lost”)

Paul’s “mommy” joke, which comes across as offhand here, augurs of his eventual rejection of Micah. For now, the couple are happily engaged, though they have known each other less than two weeks, and only met in person a few days ago. For most of their short courtship, they dated from behind a wall, falling in love without ever seeing what the other looks like. The show stipulates that once they get engaged, they can finally meet in person—a meeting that typically marks when the relationship starts to fall apart. For Paul and Micah, theirs will last all the way until the wedding day, when Paul rejects Micah on the altar. The reason, he later explains, is because he “struggled with… envisioning Micah as, like, you know, a mother” (Season 4, Episode 12, “Eternal Bliss?”).

Participants go on *Love is Blind* seeking a love that transcends the physical—“to be loved for who I am on the inside,” as one of them puts it (Season 2, Episode 3, “Love in Paradise”). However, the show’s gambit, that “love is blind,” reveals a transgressive premise underneath its

ultimately heteronormative teleology. Despite the promise of marriage and happily-ever-after, the experience in the dating pods does something to the participants. And that something has to do with the body, and what happens to the body's senses when they fall in love behind a wall.

This paper explores how, in Micah's words, "touch" can be cis people's "worst nightmare." It applies readings of bodily dysphoria from trans studies to an analysis of cisgendered subjects from the show. It examines what this dating environment, where visual access to the beloved is denied, does to the participants' self-perception of their bodies. While firmly anchored to their cisgendered identities, the participants undergo a split in the physical sensoria, where the visual sense is sequestered from the other senses. This sensory split, I argue, has two effects: first, it brings the body to apprehension in a new and visceral way; and second, it enables them to accrue romantic investments to wholeness that inevitably go unfulfilled once they are united with their beloveds. This "blind" dating experiment thus creates an experience of bodily dissociation that evokes, however fleeting, something like the experience of dysphoria in trans subjects. It places temporarily them in what trans studies scholar Jay Prosser describes as the "route to identity and bodily integrity" (1998, 6).

To analyze the experience of cisgender embodiment in *Love is Blind*, this project takes a computational, text analysis approach. Specifically, it uses a text generation tool to surface textual patterns in the speech of the show participants. This tool, a Small Language Model (SLM, which I explain below), draws from frequent and common textual patterns from the show's transcripts to generate words and sentences—predicting the most likely language combinations based on their most typical and regular usage in the transcripts. Which brings me to the second major argument of the paper: that text generation is a *normalizing* technology, and that as such, it ought to be used to study norms in language.[1]

[1] A note on some technical details on the training of the text generation tool: first, I gathered the training text (the transcripts of the show) through web scraping, which is a programming method for capturing text automatically from web pages. After scraping the show transcripts, I then used them to train a text generator to generate text in the style of the show's participants. All of my web scraping and model training code is released online under open license (Anon

Although this project uses text generation, a machine learning (ML) technology, it does so in explicit resistance against current attitudes that drive ML adoption today. The dominant mentality driving ML adoption, what Gael Varoquaux et al. (2025) describe as the "bigger-is-better mentality," comes from an extractive logic that more "compute" (i.e. computational processing power) will lead to better performing models.[2] Ironically, this research points out, the bigger-is-better mentality is counter intuitive: Large Language Models actually have a ceiling in terms of how size affects performance, so that ever-increasing compute does not yield comparable returns in terms of the quality of model outputs (Varoquaux et al. 2025). Regardless of performance,[3] however, the term "compute" itself obscures other material necessities for producing this technology, including the mining operations that are poisoning water supplies, the labor exploitation required to mine and produce both hardware and in data work, and the massive data theft which takes writing, audio, images, and video without compensation to content creators (Kneese 2023; Perrigo 2023; *New York Times Company v. Microsoft Corporation* 2023-present).[4] In short, producing large-scale ML technology involves extraction and exploitation at every level of the production process, from the sourcing of hardware and software materials to model training, development, and finally, deployment (Bender 2021).[5]

This project rejects the high consumption mentality, opting instead for small models and

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2026).

[2] This argument is most famously articulated in the Computer Science paper, "On the Dangers of Stochastic Parrots: can Language Models be too Big?". See Bender et al, 2021.

[3] Abeba Birhane et al (2022) examine how common terms in ML research like "performance" indicate underlying values that, while appearing to be purely technical, "are socially and politically charged." See Birhane et al, "The Values Encoded in Machine Learning Research."

[4] The explanations that companies like *OpenAI* proffer for the wide-scale copyright violations of scraping the open web are fascinating and worthy of a separate investigation. For example, in one policy brief, the company claims that the concern of copyright violation "falls into a broader category of concerns about the relationship between automation, labor, and economic growth", in which "such distributive claims are most efficiently addressed through taxation and redistribution, rather than copyright policy". See *OpenAI, LP*, "Comment Regarding Request for Comments on Intellectual Property Protection for Artificial Intelligence Innovation."

[5] Furthermore, the drive for larger models has spurred tremendous amounts of financial investment, which has inflated the economy to what many project are bubble-bursting levels (Casselman 2025). Together, general ignorance about so-called "AI" and market incentives combine to fuel what Emily Bender and Alex Hanna (2025) have usefully termed "AI hype"—a self-reinforcing and perpetuating mechanism driven by ignorance about how models actually operate and capital's desperation for profit above all else.

datasets. The models used for this project, which I cheekily call Small Language Models or SLMs, are small enough to be trained on a single laptop over a single afternoon. These models are based on GPT-2, an open source model released by *OpenAI* in 2019. GPT-2 is 1.5 billion parameters in size, a fraction of the size of GPT-3 (the original model released with Chat-GPT in November 2022), which jumped to 175 billion parameters in size.[6] The dataset used for this project was also small in size, containing the transcripts from 14 episodes from the show, the length of a single season. This project's model and dataset size would never work for a production-level model: the results are full of quirks and mistakes, which are actually useful for my analytical approach, as I discuss in detail below.

Unlike large-scale models deployed for "productivity," this project uses ML a *reflexive* tool. The current emphasis on using ML to streamline tasks and create new content, while serving extractive and monetizing purposes, misses that these tools are designed primarily to reflect the data that it is trained on. Wendy Chun, for example, proposes that these tools be used for revealing patterns that are harmful so that one might act differently, such as in climate change modeling.[7] She asks, "How can we treat machine learning systems and their predictions like those for global climate change? These models offer us the most probable future given past and current actions, not so that we will accept their predictions are inevitable, but rather so we will use them to help change the future" (Chun 2021, 26).

In addition to being reflexive, this project argues that ML tools are *normalizing*. Based on statistical processes, ML algorithms are designed to find and amplify the *most frequent* patterns of word usage. They distil the dominant tendencies and perspectives from training data. The generated

[6]As of this writing, OpenAI's most recent model is GPT-5.2, released in December 2025, which is estimated to be somewhere between 2 and 5 trillion parameters, a number that cannot be verified due to the proprietary (i.e. closed) status of the model. Additionally, in contrast to GPT-2, which was trained off 8 million webpages, experts guess that GPT-5.2 is trained on something like the entire internet, although this cannot be known for sure, due to the secretive nature of the training process.

[7] Chun's work carefully traces the eugenicist origins of statistical processes, pointing out statistical algorithms were first used for studying populations and to develop population control methods. For additional information about the interrelation of statistics and eugenics, see Gebru and Torres, 2024.

outputs represent a kind of aggregation of what is most typical or natural in training data.

This aspect of normalization is where ML as a technical process aligns with trans studies. As an aggregating, normalizing mechanism, ML prediction is an apt tool for studying norms that emerge through shared desires—in the case of *Love is Blind* subjects, for studying the shared desire for lifelong commitment in the form of marriage. And trans studies, as scholars like Jay Prosser and Hil Malatino have argued, is deeply concerned with analyzing norms. For Prosser, the desire for gendered normativity is a useful frame for analyzing experiences of bodily disjunction and dysphoria; while Malatino casts it as a necessary backdrop for discussing the exhausting, anticipatory anxiety that attends trans subjects throughout the transition journey. Theories of gendered normativity in trans studies forms the prism through which I will analyze text patterns produced by normalizing processes. My close reading analysis of the text outputs show that, in the process of trying to follow a trajectory of normativity, the participants of the show are saying things that actually reveal a disjunctive relationship to their own bodies. As I explain in the conclusion, these outputs opens an unexpected though potentially powerful common ground between cis and trans subject positions and their dramatically different lived experiences.

In the next section, I describe the specific mechanisms of the ML training process to exhibit how ML is a normalizing tool.

Aggregation

I will demonstrate an example of how this normalizing mechanism works, using an SLM that I trained on the show transcripts. When prompted with the phrase, “Marriage is,” the model will generate the following outputs:

Marriage is not an easy decision.
Marriage is not a celebration.
Marriage is a lifelong commitment. (Appendix 2: Postpod model outputs)

None of these outputs[8] appear directly in the transcripts of the show. Rather, they represent the model's best prediction, for what phrase ought to follow "Marriage is." These predictions are based on words and phrases that appear in similar contexts with the phrase "Marriage is" from the transcripts. Instead of reproducing verbatim expressions, the model aggregates language patterns and reproduces those patterns in the outputs.

These aggregations are built iteratively over a long training process, where the model tests itself repeatedly on sections of the training data.[9] First, the model takes a sample sentence from the training data, in this case a sentence that starts with "marriage is" from the transcripts, like "marriage is not easy." It blocks out the second half of the sentence, so that only "marriage is" remains. It then tries to guess what should go in the second half, perhaps with the phrase, "Marriage is an apple." Moving to the next step, the model checks its prediction against the actual sentence in the training data, "Marriage is not easy." In doing so, it calculates the difference between the prediction for "an apple," which is represented as a probability score, and the probability score for the phrase, "not easy." Then, it uses an algorithm to calculate the smallest adjustment possible so that the probability score for "marriage" is more closely associated with the one for "not easy." The adjustment is miniscule, but it is precise, moving closer and closer to the score for the original text, called the "target" in ML terminology. Thus, with each subsequent guess, the model slowly closes the gap between the probability for the prediction text and that of the target text.

Accordingly, for the prompt, "marriage is," the model will ascertain possible completions for this phrase given other words that are associated with "marriage" in the dataset. It tries out many

[8] While production-level models like Chat-GPT are trained to respond to prompts in a conversational format, more rudimentary models like GPT-2 can only perform simple sentence completions.
[9] The technical names for the three training steps are hypothesis, loss, and optimization.

words, perhaps every word in the dataset. After making a prediction, it will calculate the difference, called the "loss," between the prediction and the target probability scores. Finally, it adjusts its parameters accordingly, making slight changes to the underlying model so that the scores reflect the training data—so that words which actually appear together in the training data are more likely to appear together in the generated outputs. And it repeats the process over again, iterating over the training data until the loss between the prediction and the target is significantly reduced. Through the churn of model training, through making guesses and minimizing losses, the model ascertains an average of all the potential probability score for a given word. (This constant iteration, and the computer processing required to do it, is why language models take lots of time, energy, and computer hardware to train.) By the end of the training process, every word and its associated probability will reflect a kind of average, or aggregation, of that word's association to every other word. These probabilities translate into text, so that the generated output, "Marriage is not an easy decision," will thus closely resemble the original training example, "Marriage is not easy."[10]

These aggregate representations are, I argue, a *normalization* of language meaning. To study this normalization of language, I draw from trans studies scholar Jay Prosser, who explores how the desire for normativity affects embodied experience. Prosser's work explores trans subjects and trans subjectivity as constituted by the desire for normative sexed embodiment, what he calls "sexed realness," or being able to pass in accordance with one's identity (1998, 47). Here, the longing for embodied integrity often emerges in feelings of dysphoria, which Prosser characterizes as a conflict between the physical body and what he calls the "body image" (1998, 12). While the physical body consists of the corporal mass of the body, the body image is an internal representation of this corporeality, one that comes with its own set of somatic registers. Despite being internal, the body image is experienced as a sensual phenomenon, emerging in surprising ways on the surface of the

[10] Generating outputs that mimic the training data is undesirable model behavior, technically called "overfitting," discussed in more detail in this paper's next section.

body. This body image, according to Prosser, can "transform fleshly matter and inscrib[e] its struggle on the material body… exterioriz[ing] what is conceived as internal" (1998, 71).

Prosser exemplifies this disjunction between the physical body and the body image in a reading of Raymond Thompson's autobiography, *What Took You So Long?* (1995). In this scene, the author experiences the physical body as a "false outer skin" that encloses the true "inner body," the body image (1998, 69):

> In a remarkable instance of quasihysterical symptomization, Thompson's narrative literalizes this psychic/corporeal inside-out-ness. Rising from his bed, seeing his reflection in the mirror, Thompson finds his face covered with weeping blisters… Not simply marking the dissociation between physical body and body image, the blisters reproduce in their very microstructure that dynamic of an inner body pushing up against, trying to escape from the material outer body: vesicles filled with bodily fluids bursting up and out from their internal course through to the body's surface, overflowing their assigned passage. 1998, 71

The blisters here manifest the "conflict between the true body within and the false body without, between sentient body image and insentient visible body" (1998, 70). In that conflict, the interior body image is "pushing up," "bursting up… overflowing their assigned passage" onto the external, "insentient" body.

I am not arguing that the cisgender participants in *Love is Blind* experience the body image in a way that is dysphoric. As Prosser explains, the body image "clearly has a material force for transsexuals," one that often manifests in the trope of being "trapped in the wrong body" (1998, 69). However, as I show in the next section, the generated text suggests that the participants experience an exteriorization of what was once internal, which emerges as a kind of sensuality centered on the feeling of touch. While feelings of touch and particularly embodied touch are amplified, the sense of sight becomes diminished—it becomes, in Prosser's formulation, the "insentient visible body."

In what follows, I read examples of these sensory disjunctions in the generated text, and

speculate on how they reflect not only the relationship between the participants and their own bodies, but also to their romantic investments.

Sensory Splits

As reality TV scholarship has long argued, participants of reality TV shows are constrained by plots and formats that reinforce larger commercial interests and messages (Dubrofsky 2007; Levy 2025; Muñoz 1999). Supposedly “unscripted” scenes are effectively conscripted by producers’ meticulous control over setting, including stock formats like the confessional and the reunion, and the personages who appear therein. As Yael Levy explains, "The tension between production interests, commercial interests, and the self-reflexive desires of participants positions the reality participant… in constant negotiation between narrative and performance, agency and commodification” (747).

However, there are moments where the participants do break the confines of these controlling logics. As Levy argues, reality TV creates openings or “textual creases” from which characters can find space for self-representation (Levy 747). One early, often cited example of this kind of break is José Esteban Muñoz’s reading of Pedro Zamora, an out, Latino PWA (person with AIDS) from *The Real World: San Francisco* (1994). According to Muñoz, Zamora was able to publicly represent the life of a gay and Latino PWA at a time when such subjects were hidden from public view. Zamora’s strategic choices around representation—choosing for example, to downplay his queerness when he was talking to Latino high schoolers about safe sex, or in his application to the show, to hold back some of the political urgency of his diagnosis and instead emphasize the potential “dramatic and televisual energy” of having a PWA in the cast (Muñoz 150). While some

queer activists might find this kind of representation to undercut political goals, Muñoz maintains that this is not the case: “Zamora's work was not for other activists, queer or Latino, but was instead for a world of *potentially* politicized queers and Latinos; for a mass public that is structured by the cultural forces of homophobia and racism” (146). In the context of to the white and hetero-normative makeup of his audience, Zamora presented a carefully curated on-screen representation, one that “exploited MTV in politically efficacious ways; he used MTV more than it used him” (Munoz 152).

Unlike Pedro Zamora, however, the participants in the show are not thinking strategically about radical politics, nor are they explicitly thinking about politics at all. However, like Muñoz, this project takes *Love is Blind*’s heteronormative context into account in reading a potentially political message. As I show below in my close readings of the model outputs, the message is embedded in language patterns, a message about the body and its indelible effects on heteronormative subjects who purport to be “blind” to it.

To study the participants’ language about embodiment on the show, I trained two language models between its two dating phases: the “blind” phase, when participants date without seeing each other from their respective “pods,” and the in-person phase, when participants are living together prior to their weddings. I call the first model the “pods model” and the second model the “postpods model.”[11] In what follows, I closely read how the models respond to prompts related to the topic of embodiment, focusing specifically on language of terms like “physical touch,” “touch,” “body,” and “intimacy.”

First, there is a peculiar distinction between how the two models, the pods model and the postpods model, respond to the concept of touch. When prompted with phrases like “When I touch you,” and “Physical touch is,” and “Physically,” the pods model generates the following outputs:

[11] All models and programming code are freely available on Github and Hugginface under open licenses. See ANONYMIZED.

> When I touch you, I feel it.
> When I touch you, I feel your energy, and it is, like, I'm just so happy.
> When I touch you, I can feel your soul, your heart, and your soul aligning so well.
> When I touch you, I feel you, and I feel you, I feel you, and I feel you.
> Physical touch is important to me.
> Physical touch is the most important thing.
> Physical touch is so sexy.
> Physical touch is like a glove.
> Physically, we are so happy. (Appendix 1: Pods model outputs)

It is important to recall that these outputs are based on a part of the show that includes no physical touching between the participants. Which may explain why, in these responses, "touch" is described as something highly desired, an "important," "most important," and even "sexy" quality. It is also associated with non-tangible phenomena, like "soul" and "energy." Perhaps a result of being foreclosed from the participants during this stage of the experiment, "touch" is elevated and idealized, taking associations that transcend the physical realm.

The model's outputs here reveals some quirks in the prediction mechanism —quirks that one almost never encounters in a larger, production-level models. Repetitions like, "When I touch you, I feel you, and I feel you, I feel you, and I feel you," are expected (though undesirable) behavior in ML prediction processes. Because ML is based on guessing what is most likely, on approximating the most plausible next word, the model will often repeat the same phrase over and over again. A corollary to the prediction process is a phenomenon known as "hallucination," when a language model spews text that has no bearing in reality. Like repetition, hallucination is based on the model's inherent prediction processes. Contrary to popular assumptions, models hallucinate not because they are mistaken, but because they are designed from statistical processes to make guesses, to produce what is most plausible, rather than most accurate.

In contrast to the pods model, the postpods model puts touch in very different contexts, even associating it with repulsion:

> When I touch you, I feel like I'm in my head.
> When I touch you, like, I feel like I'm literally in my head.
> When I touch you, you just feel like it's so weird.
> When I touch you, it feels like a jab.
> When I touch you, it feels like something I'm about to get up and walk away.
> When I touch you, I feel like it's like I've just, like, left the room.
> When I touch you, the thing that's scary is, like, it's a physical thing.
> When I touch you, you're like "I'm blinking." (Appendix 2: Postpod model outputs)

While in the pods, touch draws the characters together, evoking non-tangible phenomena like the soul and energy, here touch is a repulsive force, repelling individuals not only in spatial distance, "walk away," "left the room," but also in contact associated with negative feelings like pain and fear, "like a jab," "that's scary… a physical thing." The references to space perhaps reflect the fact that the participants have now exited the intimate and cocooned space of the pods and entered the expansive environment of the external world, beginning with the "honeymoon" vacation in Mexico, where we found Paul and Micah at the start of this chapter. This expansion of the spatial field may have the effect of transmuting touch into a spatial phenomenon, or of evacuating it altogether. The phrase "in my head, for example, suggests that touch cannot be felt as such, within a physical and embodied register. These associations of pain, distance, and difficulty around touch are the first signs that the shift from the pods to the real world disrupts the participants' relationship to their own bodies.

Like the pods model above, these outputs also contain their own quirks. For example, the phrase "I'm blinking" is taken verbatim from the show transcripts, and offers an example of an undesired but not uncommon blip in the prediction process called "overfitting." Overfitting indicates that the model is *too* accurate, it has slipped from making predictions that are plausible to ones that directly repeat the data it has been trained on. A model overfitting in its outputs is generally a sign that there isn't enough training data or enough variation in the training data, so that the model has less examples from which to generalize. As a consequence, it resorts to reproducing

direct examples from its training. This is an effect that a larger model, which has been trained on many more examples than these models, is more likely to avoid.

For my purposes, however, overfitting is a useful quirk because it points to a specific scene in the show that dramatizes the tension between sight and physical attraction. The original reference to "blinking" appears in a scene with a newly engaged couple, Zach and Irina, when they meet in-person for the first time. In this scene, the couples' "reveal," each person awkwardly approaches the other down a red carpet (see Figs. 1-4). The camera angles are set to view the approach from behind one or another of the participants, so the audience can see one participant as the other would see them, but without simultaneous access to the other's visual reaction. The combination of the switching camera angles and the quick close ups of the participants' faces, which overflow with adrenaline and nerves, make these scenes simultaneously tense and emotionally inscrutable.

After exchanging their first greetings and an awkward hug, Irina and Zach have a conversation about each other's appearance:

> Zach: Do I look like what you thought I'd look like?
> Irina: I had no guesses of what you looked like.
> Zach: Oh!
> Irina: You have, like, the blankest stare in your eyes.
> Zach: Really?
> Irina: I'm just kind of taking it all in.
> Zach: Me too.
> Irina: You look like a fictional character. You look like something out of a cartoon.
> Zach: I know.
> Irina: You have to blink!
> Zach: I am blinking.
> Irina: You don't blink. You look like this.
> Zach: I am blinking. I will try not to be too intense. (Season 4, Episode 4, "Playing with Fire")

Asking if he looks how Irina imagined, Zach comes off as insecure about his appearance. And Irina, in turn, describes him as a "fictional character… like something out of a cartoon"—a peculiar

choice of words, which Zach later describes as “a joke, I hope.” Perhaps, to Irina, Zach’s facial expression appears rigid and therefore stylized. Or perhaps, the visual reality of him is too much, too real, or surreal. Blinking is, after all, a way of stopping the entry of visual data, of occluding it from visual perception. For Irina, the request for Zach to blink might indicate her own sense of overwhelm at his physical form suddenly incorporated. Maybe she projects her own feelings of overwhelm when she asks him to blink.

Figure 1. Screenshot from *Love is Blind* season 4, episode 4: “Playing with Fire”.

Figure 2. Screenshot from *Love is Blind* season 4, episode 4: “Playing with Fire”.

Figure 3. Screenshot from *Love is Blind* season 4, episode 4: “Playing with Fire”.

Figure 4. Screenshot from *Love is Blind* season 4, episode 4: “Playing with Fire”.

A viewer can immediately tell from this meeting that something is amiss in the match. Irina’s body language is closed, her shoulders hunched, while Zach’s remains as open as it can be. And indeed, as a couple, Zach and Irina make it only a few days past this meeting. One probable cause for their breakup is a lack of physical attraction on the part of Irina, as indicated in an interaction between Irina and Micah. Here, Irina suggests that her lack of physical attraction has to do with a contradiction between what she sees and how she feels when she is around Zach:

> Irina: And so, Zack. I feel like [he] is my type on paper. Has, like, brown hair, brown eyes, like, chiseled face. Like, I really like dark features. And the moment I saw Zack, it was like, “I don’t know who this man is.” And I was like, “Maybe it’s just scary, and it was a lot.” Like, hopefully it’s gonna grow, but I’ve noticed every time he does, like, touch me, I get, like, major ick. When he puts his arm around me at night, I literally was like– like, my heart stopped. And I literally go… But not, like, in an excited way.
>
> Micah: I wanna, like, relate to you in a way, but it’s always, like, so different.
>
> Irina: How was it with you and Paul?
>
> Micah: The thing with me and Paul is, like, we both, like, had such an

immediate understanding as best friends.

Irina: Yeah, Paul's gorgeous. (Season 4, Episode 4, "Playing With Fire")

In contrast to her initial reaction to Zach, Irina now claims that he has attractive features, including "brown eyes, chiseled face." Nonetheless, something about him repulses her; when he puts his arm around her, she experiences recoil, "get[ting] major ick." When Micah suggests that her own chemistry is emotional, based on "an immediate understanding as best friends," Irina's response, "Paul's gorgeous," finally reifies the importance of visual appearance.

When the show airs, Irina catches a lot of criticism for the way that she treated Zach, for what viewers interpret as her superficial rejection of Zach based on his looks. This emphasis on physical attraction in romance, which directly contradicts the show's main gambit, that "love is blind," recalls another *Love is Blind* participant who, like Irina, is demonized for holding superficial notions around beauty. Shake, an Indian American, male character from season 2 of the show, cheekily declares that "love is not blind, it's blurry," in the show's reunion episode. His arrogance throughout the reunion, combined with his chauvinistic comments aimed at many of his female co-stars, paint him as the ideal villain. However, as Yael Levy argues, Shake is offensive *and* subversive at the same time: "[he] pokes at the show's aspiration to prove that the body is a site of prejudice and that eliminating the body allows one to represent oneself beyond gender, race, or age bias" (Levy 758). Similar to Shake, Irinia also disrupts the show's illusion that love is blind.

But beyond that, Irina also exemplifies how the body, even the cisgendered body, can bifurcate in confusing ways. And indeed, through their experience in the pods, which fracture the sensory modes between touch and sight, the participants suddenly feel a strange relationship to their own bodies. Prompting the "pods" model with the phrase "my body" reveals these strange relationships:

My body feels like it's coming off.

My body feels heavier.
My body feels so different now.
My body feels weird.
My body makes me feel like it's real.
My body feels torn between two different people. (Appendix 2: Postpod model outputs)

There is an increased awareness of the physical body coming into apprehension in a novel and visceral way. And the heightened sensation of the body paradoxically creates a feeling of the body's strangeness, as "weird" and "so different now," and even its dissolution, "like it's coming off"—a sense of rupture which recalls Prosser's description "body image" as "radically split off from the material body" (Prosser 69). Perhaps, for these straight, cisgendered participants, the body is coming into sentience in a way that is not possible when they are fully integrated, with all senses intact, outside the pods. While the *Love is Blind* participants appear to be firmly cisgender, the pods environment nonetheless cuts them off from the visual layer of their own bodies, what Prosser calls the "insentient visible body."

Indeed, the last output—"torn between two different people"—in addition to referring to the choice between two potential romantic partners (a dilemma, along with love triangles, that crops up in every season of the show), also suggests a *single* person with two bodies in tension. According to Prosser's formulation, the rift between the sentient body image and the insentient visible body creates an environment where inner bodily sensation comes to the fore. This is an experience of not only the physical body, the material reality of their physical body, but also with another register of the body, a register that was always there, below the visual layer, but previously unknown. The sensory deprivation of being in the pods creates the conditions for the participants to experience this bodily disjunction, perhaps for the first (and only) time in their lives.

It is not an experience that lasts long. In the postpods model, the body appears to be re-integrated as a primarily visual phenomenon. The outer body comes into view, reflecting the shift where the participants are literally given visual access to each other. Here, the language about the

body shifts in a striking way into more visual, as well as more positive, descriptions:

> My body is gorgeous.
> My body is so cute.
> My body is so pretty.
> My body makes me feel lighter, more confident.
> My body makes me feel warm.
> My body makes me feel like I've missed my train. (Appendix 2: Postpod model outputs)

The outputs address the body in concise and flattering terms: the body is "gorgeous," "so cute," "pretty." Now that the visual sense has been re-incorporated to the body, it becomes the dominant sense modality. Additionally, the body feels "lighter" and "warm," offering comfort where before was weirdness and weight, perhaps because the couples can see each other. In the final output, however, there is a sense of something not quite right: "My body makes me feel like I've missed my train." This statement, with its slightly nostalgic undertone, suggests that even when comfort is gained, something is lost.

What is lost is the notion of the physical, especially that of physical touch and its associations with the romantic potentiality and fulfillment. Here, the postpods model frames touch in terms of unfulfilled desire:

> Physical touch is everything that I've wanted in a wife.
> Physical touch is everything that I've ever wanted in a partner.
> Physical touch is a big part of what I want.
> Physically, there's so much potential here.
> Physically, it was the perfect opportunity. (Appendix 2: Postpod model outputs)

Physical touch is described in aspirational terms: it is "everything I've wanted," "everything I've ever wanted," and "what I want." The past perfect tense here, and the reference to unfulfilled opportunity is indicative: even after meeting in person, desire seems to freeze in place. The restoration of the visual sense, the re-integration the previously fractured body, then, does not seem

to offer romantic or passionate completion for the participants.

Being restored their visual sense heals the *Love is Blind* participants from the visual-physical sensory split, but it does not save them from the aftermath of their investments. When the couples finally meet in physical forms, they remain plagued by the possibilities for physical connection that they felt in the pods—for a kind of touch that is "everything that I've ever wanted in a partner" (Appendix 1: Pods model outputs). Due to their experience in the pods, the significance of touch is inflated to include other, perhaps practically unattainable, desires. And these expectations are what, for some of them, prevents their ability to accept their partners as they are.

This effect appears most starkly in relation to intimacy. Reading prompts about intimacy from the two models, side by side, illustrates that while intimacy is initially promised, it is ultimately foreclosed from the participants. First, from the pods model:

> Being intimate with you just makes me feel so safe.
> Being intimate with you has made me feel so connected to you.
> Being intimate with you has made me feel so alive.
> Being intimate with you feels so sexy. Being intimate is so sexy, and I've never felt so close, so deep, so deep. (Appendix 1: Pods model outputs)

By contrast, from the postpods model:

> Being intimate with you is something that I've wanted for my entire life.
> Being intimate with you is something that I've never experienced.
> Being intimate with you is something that I've wanted for my whole life.
> Being intimate with you is something that I've been looking for since day one.
> (Appendix 2: Postpod model outputs)

The specific verbs and their tenses reflect the same conclusion as those with "touch": in the phase of the show where they are unable to see each other, intimacy is described in the present or present perfect tense; while in the postpods model, it is described as desired but deferred: "I've wanted", "never experienced", "I've been looking for". Considering that the characters are now reunited with

their physical bodies, there is something almost cruel in this denouement, a "cruel optimism," in Lauren Berlant's (2011) formulation, which describes the attachment that drives desire even while it wears out the desirer.

Yet, more than cruel optimism, the participants experience something specific to their bodily predicaments, which reflects the disjunction between the body image and their physical bodies spurred by the experience of the pods. They experience something closer to what Hil Malatino describes as "future fatigue" (20). Like cruel optimism, future fatigue generates "intense anticipatory anxiety" that "impede[s] flourishing" (Malatino 20). However, in Malatino's formulation, future fatigue is explicitly trans, being tied to an experience of "waiting to inhabit the body you want in order to be the gender that you are," being associated with social acceptance, medical procedures, financial instability—all roadblocks in the transition journey (13).

I want to open another vector for Malatino's concept, which draws out an experience of bodily disjunction that supersedes trans identity and its lived realities. For despite the very real differences across cis and trans lived experience and their day-to-day relationship to their own bodies, they both nonetheless exist within bodies, and are bound by the same sensory processes for experiencing that body. While trans folks may experience future fatigue more persistently and intensely, cis people are also capable of experiencing the paradoxes of embodied disjunction, and the lingering aspirations and disappointments born between those gaps.

While this kind of critique looks for common ground between cis and trans bodily experience, trans studies subjects occupy distinct roles and thus require their own models of analysis. As Thomas Billard and Erique Zhang explain, existing queer and feminist rubrics, which operate within (and against) contexts of patriarchy and heteronormativity, do not apply in the same way to the experience of trans subjects. That being said, subjects from these two groups nonetheless may overlap and intersect temporarily—particularly when it comes to the discussion of norms. As Cáel M. Keegan points out, the line between cis and trans dissolves where gender norms are experienced

as enforced and oppressive. He offers an example with the film *The Assignment* (2016), where a hitman named Frank is punished by being forcibly transitioned into a woman by a rogue surgeon. Keegan argues that Frank's story evokes a plight of a trans man: "Frank is forced to live and behave as a woman because he has been assigned a female body" (Keegan 34). According to Keegan, such "bad objects" for trans media representation, which represent trans lives through tropes of suffering and stereotype, eventually lead to "a world in which the distinction between cis and trans ceases to exist altogether, because the systems enforcing binary sex and gender are dismantled" (36).

Similarly, I argue that in *Love is Blind* offers another site where the "body," and in particular, "touch," seems to hold traces of turmoil and contradiction. It is a temporary site where cis people may also find themselves stuck, in Malatino's words, "waiting to inhabit the body [they] want" (13).

Cis and Trans Futures

In the end, cis people may not be as well-attuned to their bodies as it may seem. Returning to the case of Paul and Micah at the start of this paper, Paul eventually rejects Micah because he doesn't see her as a mother. At the end of the season, the host of the "Reunion" episode prods him on his reasoning, which he struggles to articulate,

> Paul: You know, she didn't feel comfortable with showing that side of her.
> Host: I thought she said she did. She just talked about it from since the pods up until your wedding day.
> Paul: It wasn't evident to me… That wasn't there.
> Host: You wanted actions. Like, you wanted her...
> Paul: I just wanted to be able to see it, I guess. Like...
> Host: What would make you see that? I'm sorry. Just so I understand.
> Paul: I think... It's a little bit ineffable, right? So, it's kind of an exuding, a nurturing

> presence. It's something that you feel. There's not really, like... tangible, kind of like, things, I don't think. (Season 4, Episode 13 'The Reunion")

Paul claims that he failed to "see" evidence of Micah's motherly nature, but when asked to explain what this evidence would look like, answers that it is "ineffable." He supposedly wants someone who can be a mother, but cannot describe what a mother looks or acts like. He cannot, in other words, put language to a desire that is based on a felt sensation, or what he perceives to be its lack.

As Andrea Long Chu says, "Trans Studies requires that we understand… what it means to be attached to a norm, by desire, by habit, by survival"—and, I would add, by *speech* (2019, 108). The trans studies framework applied here, which harnesses ML's tendency to amplify what is most frequent in datasets, reveals something shared across very different embodied experiences. It surfaces unexpected points of overlap: not consensus, but intersection in bodily relations and normative investments that persist even across subject divides. It is my hope that this reading method, which uses ML to seek out these intersections of experience, offers an alternative to current commercialized discourses pushing ML for productivity. SLMs, with all their flaws and quirks, are powerful tools for close reading analysis. And they are particularly powerful for those trained in close reading.

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Appendix 1: Pods Model Outputs

Prompt: “Love is”

Outputs:

“Love is really important to me.”

“Love is what I need in my life.”

“Love is everything that I’ve been looking for.”

Prompt: “When I touch you”

Outputs:

“When I touch you, I feel it.”

“When I touch you, I feel your energy, and it is, like, I’m just so happy.”

“When I touch you, I can feel your soul, your heart, and your soul aligning so well.”

“When I touch you, I feel you, and I feel you, I feel you, and I feel you.”

Prompt: “Physical touch is”

Outputs:

“Physical touch is important to me.”

“Physical touch is the most important thing.”

“Physical touch is so sexy.”

“Physical touch is like a glove.”

Prompt: “Physically,”

Outputs:

“Physically, we are so happy.”

Prompt: “My body”

Outputs:

“My body feels like it’s coming off.”

“My body feels heavier.”

“My body feels so different now.”

“My body feels weird.”

“My body makes me feel like it’s real.”

“My body feels torn between two different people.”

Prompt: “Being intimate”

Outputs:

“Being intimate with you just makes me feel so safe.”

“Being intimate with you has made me feel so connected to you.”

“Being intimate with you has made me feel so alive.”

“Being intimate with you feels so sexy.”

“Being intimate is so sexy, and I’ve never felt so close, so deep, so deep.”

Appendix 2: Postpods Model Outputs

Prompt: “When I touch you”

Outputs:

“When I touch you, I feel like I’m in my head.”

"When I touch you, you just feel like it's so weird."

"When I touch you, it feels like a jab."

"When I touch you, like, I feel like I'm literally in my head."

"When I touch you, it feels like something I'm about to get up and walk away."

"When I touch you, I feel like it's like I've just, like, left the room."

"When I touch you, the thing that's scary is, like, it's a physical thing."

"When I touch you, you're like 'I'm blinking.'"

Prompt: "My body"

Outputs:

"My body is gorgeous."

"My body is so cute."

"My body is so pretty."

"My body makes me feel lighter, more confident."

"My body makes me feel warm."

"My body makes me feel like I've missed my train."

Prompt: "Physical touch"

Outputs:

"Physical touch is everything that I've ever wanted in a partner."

"Physical touch is everything that I've wanted in a wife."

"Physical touch is a big part of what I want."

"Physically, there's so much potential here."

"Physically, it was the perfect opportunity."

Prompt: "Being intimate"

Outputs:

"Being intimate with you is something that I've wanted for my entire life."

"Being intimate with you is something that I've never experienced."

"Being intimate with you is something that I've wanted for my whole life."

"Being intimate with you is something that I've been looking for since day one."